

MANDAR DEODHAR

MEOWS CORNER
Visitors at Cat Studio, a cat adoption centre in Mumbai

TREATING 'EM RIGHT

A trip to the vet is no longer the same either. As Dr M. Shreyas, 24, who is studying to be a second-generation vet from Bengaluru, says, "The days of vets being there just for rabies vaccination and deworming are long behind us. It is a very exciting time to be a vet today because you can specialise in so many new fields and there are enough job opportunities that were not there in my father's time."

Brothers Kunal and Bhanu Sharma, pet orthopaedist and pet cardiologist, respectively, run Max Vets in Delhi. When their father S.D. Sharma started the clinic in 1959, it functioned out of the basement of a building in the city's Greater Kailash-I area. Today, it is a flourishing three-floor small animal hospital, with dedicated pet ICUs, X-ray and MRI scanners, operating units and a 24-hour emergency response helpline. Here, pets can get cataract surgery, spinal adjustments, heart procedure, cavities removed, even chemotherapy or a simple blood transfusion. Prices vary from Rs 1,000 for a tick-cleaning session to Rs 5,000 for a specialised MRI scan and Rs 20,000 for an operation.

What if your pet is lonely or depressed? In that case, a trip to the shrink may not be amiss. In Chennai, Purnima Rao, 44, is the person troubled pet parents turn to, and swear by the combination of behavioural therapy, reiki, acupuncture and massage therapy she uses to ease her clients' blues away. Rao's most recent patient was a 10-year-old male Russian Blue cat suffering from severe loneliness. "I healed him by connecting to his pain," says Rao. "He had lost his brother a month ago. I advised his parents to get him a new companion. He is now happier because some cats do better in company." Her charges are Rs 5,000 per session and publicity only by word of mouth—she accepts a client only if it has been referred by a previous client. Having done online courses in pet psychology, she is seeing her business grow. "From two clients a year in 2010, I now get two to three a week," she says. "But I do not accept them all because my therapy is based on energy vibrations. If I start healing every animal, then I will burn out. I keep my services exclusive and for those whom I trust." Rao says she does it out of love and a sense of personal purpose, not for money or fame.

FOR THE LOVE OF DOG

HUFT's Dasgupta cannot agree more—you just can't be in the pet business if you don't have love and compassion for animals. "To stand out in the pet economy space, you need to care about pets. After all, a pet parent will trust